AI Made Easy for Seniors

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A Large-Print, Step-by-Step Guide to Asking an AI Assistant Anything — Write Emails, Plan Trips, Check Health Questions, Learn New Hobbies and Spot Scams, on Your Phone or Computer

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Important. This book is for general information and education. It is not medical, legal, or financial advice. AI assistants can make mistakes: always check important information with a qualified professional or an official source. In an emergency, call your local emergency number. AI apps and their features change often; the steps in this book describe them as they were at the time of writing.

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Examples. The people, messages, and conversations in this book's examples are fictional. Any resemblance to real persons is coincidental.

First edition, 2026.

To my father and my mother,
for your love, your sacrifices, and every lesson you taught me.

To my wife,
for your patience, your encouragement, and your belief in me.

And to our three children,
may you always build the things you dream of.

This book is for you.

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Introduction

Welcome. If you have heard people talk about "AI" and wondered what all the fuss is about, or whether it is something for you, this book is for you.

An AI assistant is a program you can talk to in plain English. You ask a question or describe what you need, and it writes back an answer, in a few seconds, any time of day or night. It never gets tired of your questions. It never makes you feel silly for asking. And it is far easier to use than most people expect.

Here are a few things readers like you use it for every day:

- Writing a warm thank-you note, or a firm letter to a company
- Planning a trip with plenty of rest stops and step-free hotels
- Understanding a word on a doctor's letter before the next appointment
- Turning what is in the fridge into tonight's dinner
- Learning about birds, history, gardening or a new language
- Checking whether a strange text message might be a scam

You do not need to be "good with computers." If you can send a text message or an email, you can use an AI assistant.

How This Book Works

This book is written in large print, with short chapters and one idea at a time. Each chapter shows you exactly what to type, what you will see, and what to do next.

Throughout the book you will see shaded boxes like this one. They show the exact words you can type, or say out loud, to your AI assistant:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please explain what an AI assistant is, in simple words,
> as if you were talking to a friend.

You can copy these requests word for word, or change them to fit your own life. There is no wrong way to ask.

You will also see boxes like these:

> **Try It:** A short practice task, so you can learn by doing.

> **Safety Tip:** Something important to protect your money, your health or your privacy.

The Four Parts of the Book

Part I: Getting Started explains what an AI assistant is, helps you set one up on your phone, tablet or computer, and walks you through your very first conversation.

Part II: Everyday Help is the heart of the book. Each chapter covers one area of life: letters and emails, trips, health questions, the kitchen and garden, hobbies, family, and paperwork.

Part III: Staying Safe shows you how to spot scams, including new ones that use AI, how to protect your privacy, and what to do when the AI gets something wrong.

Part IV: Going Further shows you how to talk instead of type, how to use your camera with an AI, and gives you a simple one-week practice plan.

At the back of the book you will find **100 ready-to-use questions**, a **plain-English word list**, and a **quick reference page** you can keep beside your phone.

A Word About Mistakes

You cannot break anything by asking an AI assistant a question. If you do not like an answer, you simply ask again in a different way. If you get lost, you can start a fresh conversation with one tap.

The AI, on the other hand, *can* make mistakes, and this book will show you how to catch them. The golden rule is simple: **use AI for help**

and ideas, and check anything important with a doctor, a pharmacist, your bank, or another trusted source.

A Gift Worth Opening Slowly

Perhaps someone gave you this book as a gift. If so, they were thinking of you, and you might enjoy trying the first few chapters together. Learning side by side is one of the nicest ways to begin.

There is no rush. Read a chapter, try one or two of the examples, and come back tomorrow. In a week, you will be surprised how natural it feels.

Let's begin.

PART I

Getting Started

CHAPTER 1

What an AI Assistant Is (and Isn't)



A grandmother and grandfather at the kitchen table, smiling as they read an answer on a tablet.

Let's start with the big question: what exactly is an AI assistant?

"AI" stands for **artificial intelligence**. It is a type of computer program that has learned from an enormous amount of written text: books, articles, websites, instructions and conversations. From all that reading, it has learned how language works and a great deal about the world.

An **AI assistant** is an app or a website where you can chat with one of these programs. You type (or speak) a message, and the assistant writes a reply. You can then answer back, ask a follow-up question, or ask it to change something. It works much like texting a very well-read friend.

What It Feels Like

Imagine you write:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> What is a good gift for my grandson who is 12 and loves football?

A few seconds later, the assistant replies with a short list of ideas: a ball signed by his favorite team, a book about famous players, tickets to a local game, a training jersey with his name on the back. Then you can ask for more:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> He already has a lot of football gear.
> Something under $30 that isn't clothing?

And it gives you new ideas that fit. That back-and-forth is the whole secret. You do not need special commands or technical words. You just talk.

What an AI Assistant Is Good At

AI assistants are especially good at:

- **Writing:** letters, emails, cards, speeches, posts and short stories
- **Explaining:** turning complicated words into plain English
- **Planning:** trips, meals, weekly schedules and to-do lists
- **Ideas:** gifts, hobbies, recipes, games and conversation starters
- **Summarizing:** turning a long letter or article into a few key points
- **Practicing:** a new language, a job interview, or a hard conversation
- **Patience:** answering the same question as many times as you like

What It Is Not

It is just as important to know what an AI assistant is *not*.

It is not a person. It does not have feelings, memories of you as a friend, or a life of its own, even though it may write in a friendly way. It is a very clever tool.

It is not always right. It sometimes states things confidently that are simply wrong. Experts call this "making things up." Chapter 14 shows you how to catch it.

It is not a doctor, lawyer or financial adviser. It can help you understand things and prepare good questions, but it cannot examine you, and it does not know your full situation.

It is not a search engine, exactly. A search engine shows you a list of websites. An AI assistant reads and writes an answer for you. Many assistants can now also look things up on the web, and some show you where they found the information.

It does not know everything about today. Some assistants can look up recent news; others only know what they learned up to a certain date. If you need today's weather, train times or opening hours, check the official source.

> **Remember:** Think of an AI assistant as a knowledgeable, tireless helper who is occasionally wrong. Use it for help and ideas. Check anything important.

Where AI Already Shows Up in Your Life

You may already be using AI without knowing it:

- The voice assistant on your phone or smart speaker that sets timers and tells you the weather
- The suggested words that appear as you type a text message
- The way your email moves junk mail out of sight
- Captions that appear on videos

The AI assistants in this book go further: you can have a real conversation with them about almost anything.

Is It Safe?

Using a well-known AI assistant is about as safe as using email or a shopping website, as long as you follow a few common-sense rules. The most important ones are:

1. **Never type passwords, bank details, or your Social Security or other ID numbers** into an AI chat.
2. **Only use well-known apps** from your phone's official app store, or the company's official website.
3. **Be suspicious of anyone who pressures you** about money, whether that's a person, an email, or a voice on the phone. AI has made some scams more convincing, and Chapter 12 shows you how to spot them.

You will find these rules repeated throughout the book, because they matter.

Is It Free?

The major AI assistants offer a **free version** that is more than enough for everything in this book. Most also sell a paid plan with extra features, usually around the price of a streaming TV service each month. You do not need to pay for anything to get started. If an app asks you to upgrade, you can simply close the message.

> **Try It:** Before you set anything up, think of three things you would like help with this week. A letter you have been meaning to write? A recipe for leftover vegetables? A question about your new phone? Write them on the notes page at the back of this book. We will use them soon.

Key Points

- An AI assistant is a program you can chat with in plain English.
- It is good at writing, explaining, planning and ideas.
- It is not a person, it can make mistakes, and it is no substitute for a professional.
- Free versions are enough to start.
- Never share passwords, bank details or ID numbers with it.

CHAPTER 2

Getting Set Up on Your Phone, Tablet or Computer

In this chapter you will choose an AI assistant, install it, and make the screen comfortable to read. It takes about fifteen minutes. If you have a family member or friend nearby, this is a lovely chapter to do together.

Step 1: Choose One Assistant

There are several well-known AI assistants. They all work in a similar way, and every example in this book works with any of them. The best-known ones today are:

Assistant	Made by	Website
ChatGPT	OpenAI	chatgpt.com
Gemini	Google	gemini.google.com
Claude	Anthropic	claude.ai
Copilot	Microsoft	copilot.microsoft.com

Assistant	Made by	Website
Meta AI	Meta	meta.ai

Which one should you choose? Any of them is fine. Here is a simple way to decide:

- If a family member already uses one, choose the same one. They can help you.
- If you use an Android phone, Gemini may already be on it.
- If you are not sure, pick any one. You can always try another later.

Pick **one** and stick with it while you learn. Having several apps at once only makes things confusing.

> **Note:** Names, prices and features change often in the world of AI. If a screen looks a little different from what this book describes, look for the same idea: a box to type in, and a button to send.

Step 2: Install the App on a Phone or Tablet

On a phone or tablet, the easiest way is to install the official app.

1. Open the **app store** on your device. On an iPhone or iPad, this is the blue **App Store** icon. On an Android phone or tablet, it is the colorful **Play Store** (Google Play) icon.
2. Tap the **search** box and type the name of the assistant you chose, for example *Claude* or *ChatGPT*.

3. **Check the maker's name** under the app's name before you install anything. It should be the real company from the table above, such as OpenAI, Google, Anthropic, Microsoft or Meta.
4. Tap **Get** or **Install**. You may need to enter your app store password or use your fingerprint or face.
5. When it has finished, tap **Open**.

> **Safety Tip:** App stores contain look-alike apps with similar names and logos, some of which charge high fees. Always check the maker's name. If you are not sure, ask a family member, or use the official website from the table instead.

Step 3: Or Use It on a Computer

On a desktop or laptop computer, you do not need to install anything.

1. Open your web browser, the program you use to visit websites.
2. Click in the address bar at the very top and type the website from the table, for example **claude.ai** or **chatgpt.com**.
3. Press **Enter**.

Tip: once the page is open, add it to your **bookmarks** or **favorites** (often a star icon near the address bar), so you can find it again with one click.

Step 4: Create Your Account

The first time you open the app or website, it will ask you to sign in or create an account. Most assistants let you sign up in one of these ways:

- With your **email address**: you type your email, then the company sends you a code or a link to confirm it is really you.
- With an account you already have, such as a **Google**, **Apple** or **Microsoft** account, by tapping a button like *Continue with Google*.

Using an account you already have is usually the quickest. Follow the steps on the screen. If you are asked to make a new password, choose one you do not use anywhere else, and write it in a safe place at home, not in this book's notes page if you carry the book around.

Some apps ask for your date of birth or phone number. That is normal for well-known apps.

> **Safety Tip:** A real AI app will never ask for your bank card to start the free version. If it asks for payment before you have even tried it, stop and check that you have the right app.

Step 5: Make the Text Bigger

Comfortable reading makes everything easier. Here is how to make text larger.

On an iPhone or iPad: open **Settings**, tap **Display & Brightness**, then **Text Size**, and drag the slider to the right. For even bigger text, go to **Settings**, then **Accessibility**, then **Display & Text Size**, then **Larger Text**.

On an Android phone or tablet: open **Settings**, tap **Display** (on some phones, **Accessibility**), then **Font size** or **Font size and style**, and drag the slider to the right. The exact names vary a little between phone makers.

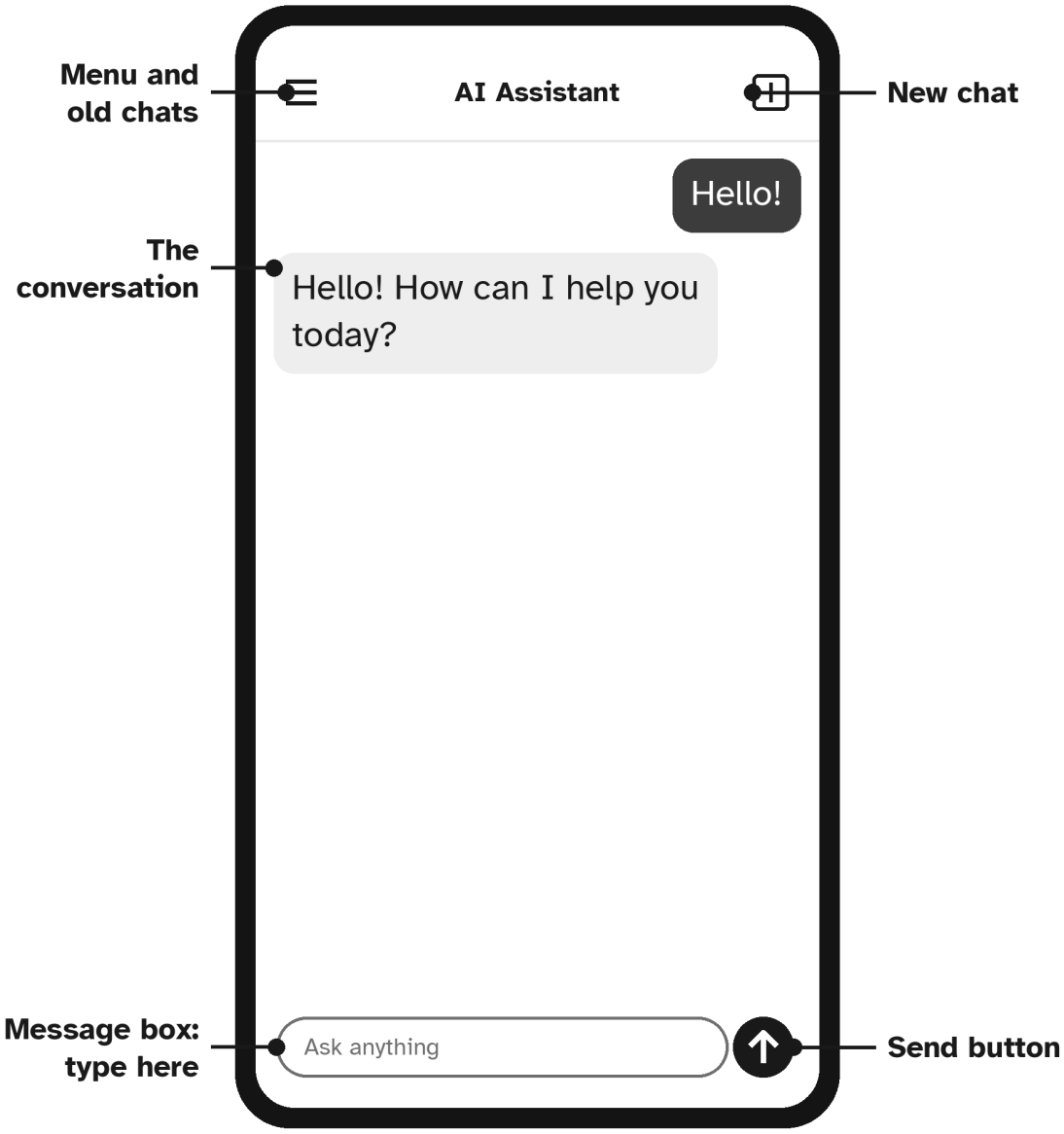
On a computer: while the AI website is open, hold down the **Ctrl** key (on a Mac, the **Command** key) and press the **plus** key (**+**) a few times. Each press makes the page bigger. To make it smaller again, use the **minus** key (**–**).

Step 6: Find Your Way Around

Every AI assistant has the same three important parts. Take a moment to find them now.

1. **The message box.** Usually at the bottom of the screen, with words like *Ask anything* or *Message*. This is where you type.
2. **The send button.** Usually an arrow next to the message box. Tap it to send your message. (On a computer, you can also press **Enter**.)
3. **New chat.** A button, often with a pencil or a plus sign, that starts a fresh conversation. You will usually find it at the top of the screen, or in a menu you open by tapping an icon of three short lines.

Many apps also show a **microphone** button for speaking instead of typing. We will use it in Chapter 15.



The main parts of an AI assistant screen: the conversation, the message box, the send button and the new chat button.

Try It: Open your AI assistant and find the message box, the send button and the new chat button. You do not need to type anything yet. Just knowing where they are is a great first step.

Key Points

- Choose one well-known assistant and stick with it while you learn.
- Install it from your official app store, and check the maker's name.
- On a computer, just visit the website.
- Make the text big enough to read comfortably.
- Find the message box, the send button and the new chat button.

CHAPTER 3

Your First Conversation

Now for the fun part. In this chapter you will have your first real conversation with an AI assistant, step by step.

Say Hello

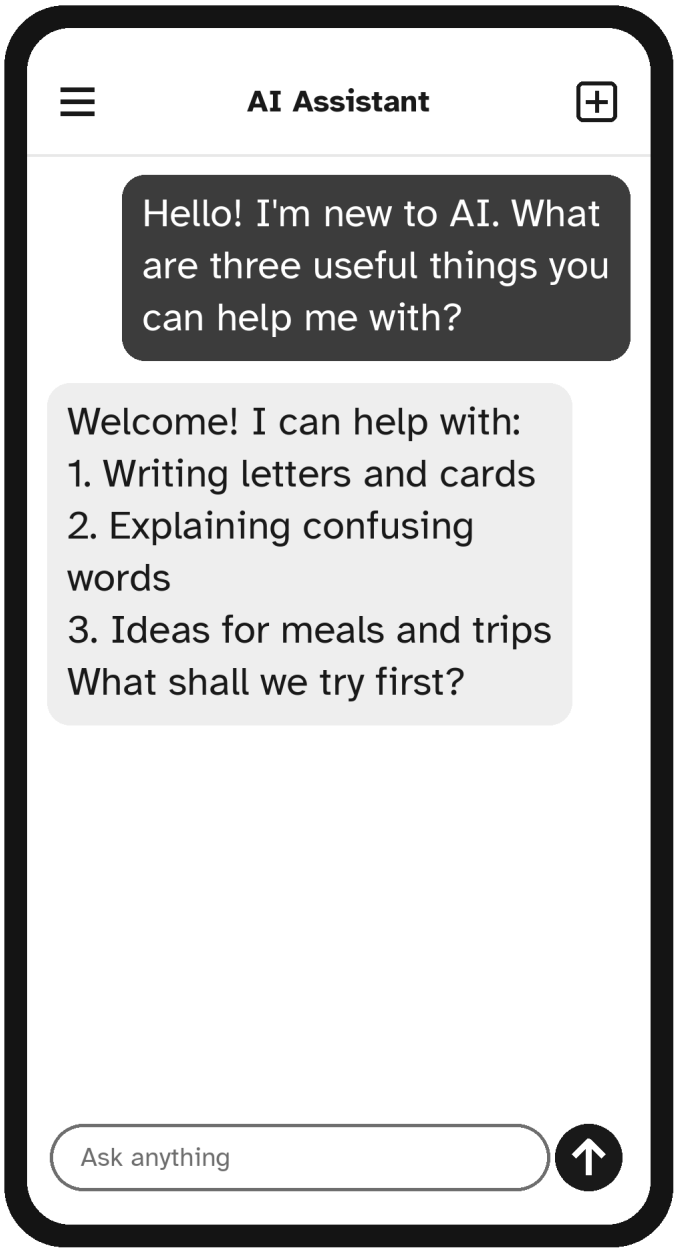
Open your AI assistant and tap the message box. Type this, exactly as it is, or in your own words:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Hello! I'm new to using AI. Can you tell me, in simple words, three useful things you can help me with?

Now tap the **send** button (the arrow).

Watch the screen. After a moment, words will start to appear. The assistant writes its answer a few words at a time, a little like someone typing. Wait until it stops.

Congratulations, you have just used AI.



Your first conversation: your message appears on one side and the assistant's reply on the other.

Read the Answer

Read the reply at your own pace. If it is long, you can scroll down by moving your finger up the screen (or using your mouse wheel on a computer).

You will probably notice a few things:

- The answer is written in friendly, everyday language.
- It may use **bold words**, numbered lists, or short headings to make things easy to scan.
- It may end with a question for you, such as "*Would you like to try one of these?*" You can answer it, or ignore it and ask something else.

Ask a Follow-Up

The real power of an AI assistant is that it remembers what you said earlier **in the same conversation**. So you can keep going, as you would in a real chat. Try this:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Thank you. Can you give me one example of the first one?

The assistant knows what "the first one" means, because it is part of this conversation.

Try a few more follow-ups in your own words. Here are some phrases that work wonderfully:

- "*Can you make that shorter?*"
- "*Can you explain that more simply?*"
- "*Can you give me another example?*"
- "*Put that in a numbered list, please.*"

- "*Write that bigger, in fewer words.*"
- "*I don't understand the word ___. What does it mean?*"

> **Remember:** You never need to be polite to a computer, but you can be. "Please" and "thank you" do no harm, and many people find it feels more natural.

Start a New Conversation

When you want to talk about something completely different, start a **new chat**. Tap the **new chat** button you found in Chapter 2 (a pencil or a plus sign).

Why start fresh? Because the assistant tries to connect everything in one conversation to what came before. If you were talking about a birthday cake and then ask about your car, the answers may get muddled. A new chat is a clean page.

A good habit: **one topic, one chat.**

Find an Old Conversation

Most assistants keep a list of your past conversations, so you can go back to them later.

- On a phone or tablet, tap the menu icon (often three short lines at the top left), and you will see a list of your chats, each with a short title.

- On a computer, the list is usually down the left side of the screen.

Tap any chat to open it and carry on where you left off.

Copy an Answer

Often you will want to use what the AI wrote, for example to paste a letter into an email.

On a phone or tablet: below most answers there is a small **copy** button, which looks like two overlapping squares. Tap it, and the whole answer is copied. Then go to your email or messages app, press and hold in the place where you type, and tap **Paste**.

On a computer: click the **copy** button below the answer. Then click where you want the text, and press **Ctrl** and **V** together (on a Mac, **Command** and **V**).

If Something Goes Wrong

Do not worry. Here are the most common hiccups and their cures.

What happens	What to do
Nothing appears after you send	Wait 20 seconds. Then check your internet connection and try again.
The answer stops halfway	Type "*Please continue.*"
You see a message about limits	You have used the free version a lot today. Wait a few hours, or come back tomorrow.

What happens	What to do
The answer is far too long	Ask: "*Please answer in three short sentences.*"
It misunderstood you	Say so, plainly: "*No, I meant ___.*"
You feel lost	Start a new chat and begin again. Nothing is lost.

Try It: Start a new chat and ask about something you love. For example: "*Tell me three interesting facts about hummingbirds.*" Then ask one follow-up question. You have now done everything you need to use AI every day.

Key Points

- Type your message, tap send, and wait for the answer to finish.
- Ask follow-up questions in plain words. The assistant remembers the conversation.
- Use **new chat** for a new topic.
- Use the **copy** button to reuse an answer.
- If anything goes wrong, try again or start a new chat.

CHAPTER 4

Five Golden Rules for Asking Well

You can ask an AI assistant anything in any way, and it will do its best. But a few simple habits make the answers much better. Here are the five golden rules. They are worth learning by heart.

Rule 1: Say What You Want, Clearly

Imagine asking a helpful neighbor, "Can you help me with the garden?" They would need to know: help with what? A clear request gets a clear answer.

Compare these two requests:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Recipe.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please give me an easy recipe for a chicken dinner
> for two people that takes less than 30 minutes.

The second one tells the assistant exactly what you want, and you will get exactly that.

Rule 2: Give It Some Background

The assistant does not know you. A sentence or two about your situation makes the answer fit your life. Useful background includes:

- **Who it is for:** "for my granddaughter who is 8"
- **Your situation:** "I live alone and cook for one"
- **Limits:** "I have bad knees, so I need to avoid stairs"
- **Your experience:** "I have never used a spreadsheet before"

For example:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am 74 and I have just bought my first tablet.
> I want to video call my daughter in Canada.
> Please explain how, in very simple steps.

Rule 3: Say How You Want the Answer

You can ask for any shape or size of answer. Just say so:

- "In **three** short sentences."
- "As a **numbered list** of steps."
- "In **large, simple** words, with no jargon."
- "As a **short email** I can send."
- "As a **shopping list**, grouped by aisle."
- "As a **table** with prices."

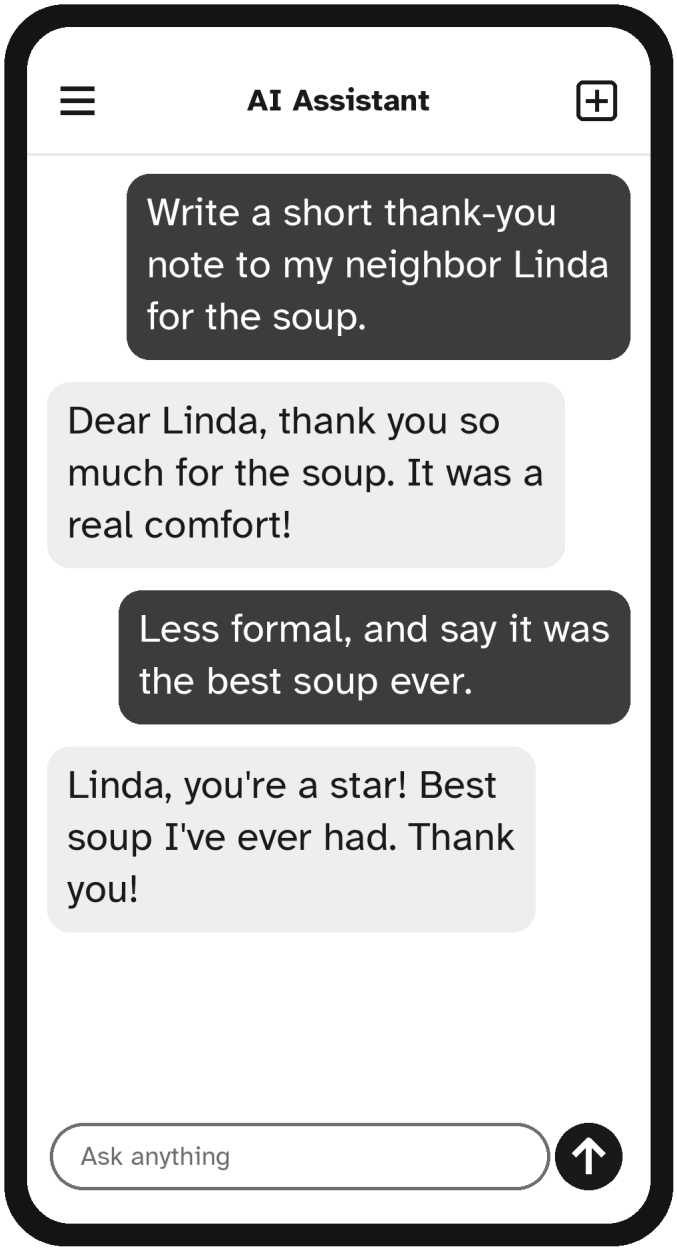
> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Explain what "the cloud" means for photos on my phone.
> Answer in three short sentences with no technical words.

Rule 4: Keep Talking

The first answer is just the beginning. If it is not quite right, do not start over. Tell the assistant what to change, as you would with a person:

- "Make it warmer and more personal."
- "That's too formal. My sister and I are close."
- "Shorter, please."
- "I don't like mushrooms. Can you change the recipe?"
- "Good, but add something about my trip to Florida."

Most of the best results come from two or three rounds of small changes.



Asking for changes: a short follow-up turns a good answer into exactly what you wanted.

Rule 5: Check Anything Important

An AI assistant is confident, but not always correct. Before you rely on an answer about your **health, money, legal matters, travel bookings or safety**, check it with a reliable source: your doctor, pharmacist, bank, an official government website, or the company itself.

A handy question to ask at the end of an important answer:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> How sure are you about this? What should I double-check, and with whom?

A good assistant will tell you which parts to confirm, and where.

A Simple Recipe for Any Request

When you are not sure how to ask, fill in this pattern:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am [who you are or your situation].
> Please help me [what you want].
> It is for [who or what it is for].
> Please [how you want the answer].

For example:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am a retired teacher who loves reading.
> Please help me choose five novels for my book club.
> It is for a group of women in their 70s who like mysteries.
> Please give a one-sentence description of each book.

You do not have to use this pattern every time. But when an answer disappoints you, it usually means one of these four parts was missing.

Try It: Choose one of the three things you wrote down in Chapter 1. Write a request using the recipe above, send it, and then use Rule 4 to improve the answer with one follow-up.

Key Points

- **Clear:** say exactly what you want.
- **Background:** a sentence about you makes the answer fit.
- **Shape:** say how long and in what form.
- **Keep talking:** improve the answer with follow-ups.
- **Check:** confirm anything important with a trusted source.

PART II

Everyday Help

CHAPTER 5

Writing Emails, Letters and Messages



A smiling man in his seventies at a desk, reading a letter he has just written with help from a laptop.

Writing is where AI assistants shine. Whether you are staring at a blank card, struggling to word a complaint, or simply want your email to sound just right, the assistant can give you a first draft in seconds. You stay in charge: you read it, change it, and send it in your own name.

A Thank-You Note

Let's start with something warm.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please write a short thank-you note to my neighbor Linda,
> who brought me soup every day while I had the flu.
> Keep it warm and simple, about four sentences.

Read the result. Does it sound like you? If not, ask for changes:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Lovely. Please make it a little less formal, and mention
> that her chicken soup was the best I've ever had.

Remember: The AI's draft is a starting point. Change any words you like. A note in your own voice always means more.

A Birthday or Holiday Message

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Write a cheerful birthday message for my grandson Leo, who turns 16 tomorrow. He loves skateboarding and just started learning to drive. Two or three sentences, with a gentle joke about driving.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Write a short Christmas card message for my old friend Margaret. We worked together for twenty years and now live far apart. Make it heartfelt but not sad.

A Letter to a Company

AI is very good at writing calm, clear letters that get results. Give it the facts, and say what you want to happen.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please write a polite but firm email to my internet company. My internet has stopped working three times this month, for a whole day each time. I have been a customer for 12 years. I would like a refund for the days without service. Keep it short and clear.

The assistant will usually leave spaces like **[Your Name]** or **[Account Number]** for you to fill in. That is deliberate: you add your personal details yourself, in your email, not in the AI chat.

> **Safety Tip:** Never type your account numbers, card numbers or passwords into the AI. Let it write the letter with blanks, then fill in the blanks yourself in your email program.

Replying to a Tricky Message

Sometimes the hard part is knowing what to say. Describe the situation, and ask for help.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My son has invited me to stay for two weeks at Christmas. I would love to see him, but two weeks is too long for me. Please help me write a kind reply suggesting one week instead, without hurting his feelings.

Improving Something You Have Written

You can also paste in your own writing and ask the AI to tidy it up. Copy your text (press and hold, then tap **Copy**), go to the AI, press and hold in the message box, tap **Paste**, and add a request:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please check the spelling and grammar in my message below, and make it a little clearer. Keep my own words as much as possible.
>
> [paste your message here]

This is wonderful for club newsletters, church notices, letters to the editor, or anything you want to get just right.

Longer Writing: Speeches and Tributes

Some writing matters deeply: a toast at a wedding, a few words at an anniversary, or a eulogy for a friend. AI can help you organize your thoughts gently.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I have been asked to say a few words at my best friend's 80th birthday party. We met at school and have been friends for 70 years. We once got lost on a camping trip and ate nothing but marshmallows for two days.
> Please help me write a two-minute speech that is warm and funny.

For a eulogy or a very personal piece, you might ask the AI for an **outline** rather than finished words, and then write it yourself:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I need to write a short eulogy for my brother, who loved fishing, his dog, and terrible jokes. Please suggest an outline with five parts, and some questions I could ask myself to remember stories about him.

Changing the Tone

You can ask for any tone of voice. Try the same message in different styles to see what you like:

- "more formal" or "more relaxed"
- "warmer" or "more businesslike"
- "funnier" or "more serious"
- "shorter" or "with more detail"

- "suitable for a child to read"

> **Try It:** Think of someone you have been meaning to write to. Ask the AI to help you write a short message to them. Change at least one sentence yourself so it sounds like you, then send it today.

Key Points

- Give the facts and say what you want; the AI writes the first draft.
- Ask for changes until it sounds like you.
- Leave personal details blank and fill them in yourself.
- Paste your own writing in to have it checked and polished.
- For very personal writing, ask for an outline and use your own words.

CHAPTER 6

Planning Trips and Days Out

Planning a trip involves a hundred small decisions: where to stay, how to get there, what to see, what to pack. An AI assistant can do the first round of thinking for you and suggest a plan that fits your pace, your budget and your needs.

A Day Out Close to Home

Start small:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
>
> I live in Columbus, Ohio. Please suggest five ideas for a relaxing day out within an hour's drive, suitable for two people in their 70s who enjoy gardens and history. Avoid anything with lots of walking or stairs.

Then narrow it down:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> The second idea sounds lovely. Please plan the day: when to leave, where to have lunch nearby, and when to head home so we are back before dark.

> **Note:** The AI may suggest restaurants or attractions that have closed or changed their hours. Before you set off, check opening times on the place's own website, or phone them.

Planning a Longer Trip

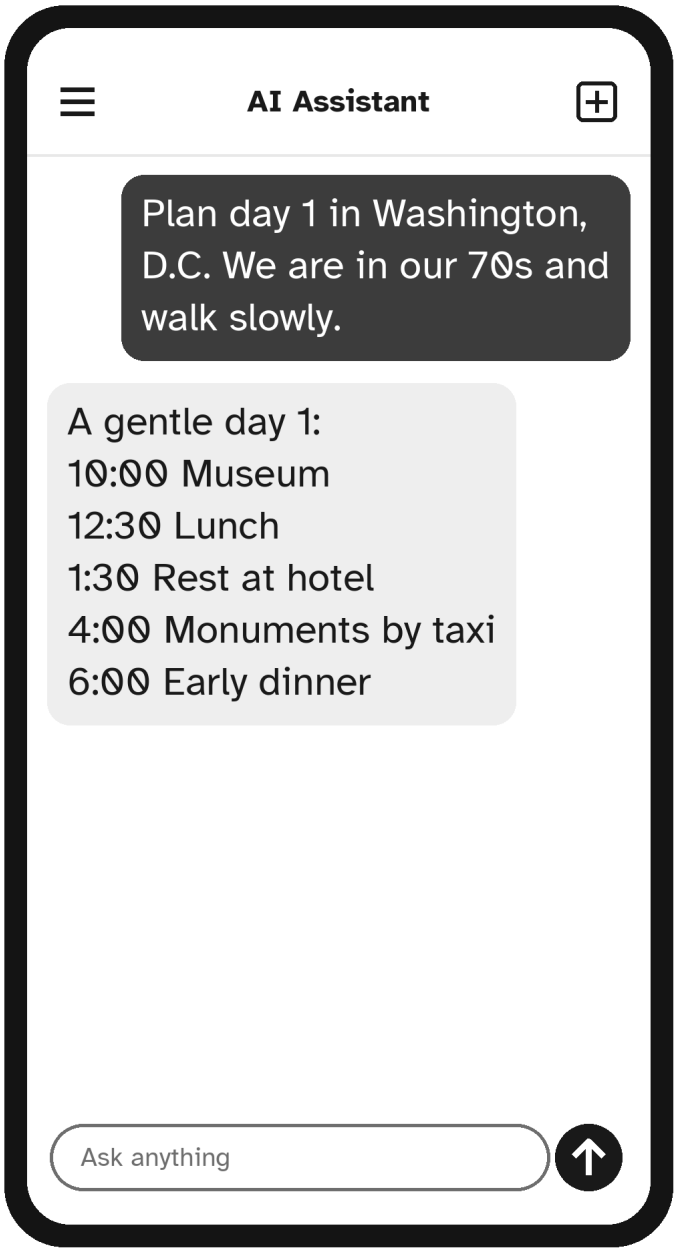
For a bigger trip, give the assistant the main facts: where, when, who, budget and any needs.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My wife and I (both 72) would like a 5-day trip to Washington, D.C., in April. We prefer a comfortable hotel near public transportation, we walk slowly, and we would like a rest every afternoon. Our budget is about $2,500 for the two of us, not including flights. Please suggest a day-by-day plan.

You will get a plan that you can shape with follow-ups:

- "Please move the museum day to Wednesday."

- "Add a nice dinner for our anniversary on the last night."
- "Which of these places have benches or wheelchairs available?"
- "What should we book in advance?"



A trip plan in a chat: a gentle day-by-day schedule with rests built in.

Travel With Health or Mobility Needs

AI assistants are very good at thinking through practical needs. Be open about yours; it helps the plan fit.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I use a walker and can manage about 15 minutes of walking at a time. What should I ask a hotel and an airline before booking, to make sure the trip is comfortable for me?

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I take medication every morning and evening. I am flying from Chicago to London. How should I adjust my medication times for the time difference? Please give me questions to ask my pharmacist.

The second example shows a good habit: for anything medical, ask the AI for **questions to bring to a professional**, not for the final answer.

Packing Lists

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please make a packing list for a 7-day cruise in the Caribbean in February, for a woman in her 70s. Include medication reminders and documents. Group it by category with checkboxes.

You can print the list, or copy it into a note on your phone.

Learning About a Place Before You Go

Part of the joy of travel is knowing a little about where you are going.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am visiting Savannah, Georgia, next month. Please tell me five interesting stories from its history that I can look out for while I'm there.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I'm going to Italy. Please teach me ten useful Italian phrases for restaurants and shops, with how to pronounce them.

What AI Cannot Do for Your Trip

An AI assistant can plan, but it generally cannot (and should not) **book or pay** for you. When you are ready:

- Book directly with the airline, hotel or a travel agent you trust, or ask a family member to help.
- Check prices, times and rules on the official websites. The AI may be out of date.
- Never give your card details to anyone who contacts you out of the blue offering a "special travel deal."

Safety Tip: Travel scams are common: fake booking websites, "free cruise" phone calls and too-good-to-be-true deals. If in doubt, close the page and book through a company you already know. Chapter 12 has more on spotting scams.

Try It: Ask the AI to plan a relaxing afternoon somewhere near you. Then ask one follow-up question to make it suit you even better.

Key Points

- Give the AI the facts: where, when, who, budget and needs.
- Improve the plan with follow-ups.
- Be open about health or mobility needs, and ask for questions to check with professionals.
- Check opening times and prices on official sites.
- Book and pay through companies you trust, never through unexpected calls or messages.

CHAPTER 7

Health Questions, Asked Safely

Many people use AI assistants to understand health information: a word on a test result, the name of a new medicine, or what to ask at the next appointment. Used wisely, it can make you a more confident, better-prepared patient. Used carelessly, it can worry you or mislead you. This chapter shows you the wise way.

> **Warning:** An AI assistant is not a doctor. It cannot examine you and does not know your full medical history. **In an emergency, such as chest pain, trouble breathing, signs of a stroke, or a bad fall, call 911 (or your local emergency number) right away.** Do not stop to ask an AI.

What AI Is Good For in Health

- **Explaining words** on letters, test results or leaflets
- **Preparing questions** for your doctor, nurse or pharmacist

- **General information** about a condition, in plain English
- **Healthy habits**: gentle exercise ideas, meal planning, sleep tips
- **Organizing**: a medication schedule chart, or a symptom diary

What It Should Never Replace

- Diagnosis: deciding what is wrong with you
- Deciding to start, stop or change any medicine
- Urgent or worrying symptoms
- Your doctor's or pharmacist's advice about *you*

Understanding Medical Words

Medical letters are full of words most people never learned. An AI can translate them.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My blood test letter says my "eGFR is 58" and my "HbA1c is 6.1%". What do these words mean, in plain English? I will discuss my results with my doctor.

Notice the last sentence. It reminds the assistant (and you) that this is for understanding, not for deciding.

Preparing for an Appointment

Doctor visits can feel rushed. Arriving with a short list of questions helps you make the most of the time.

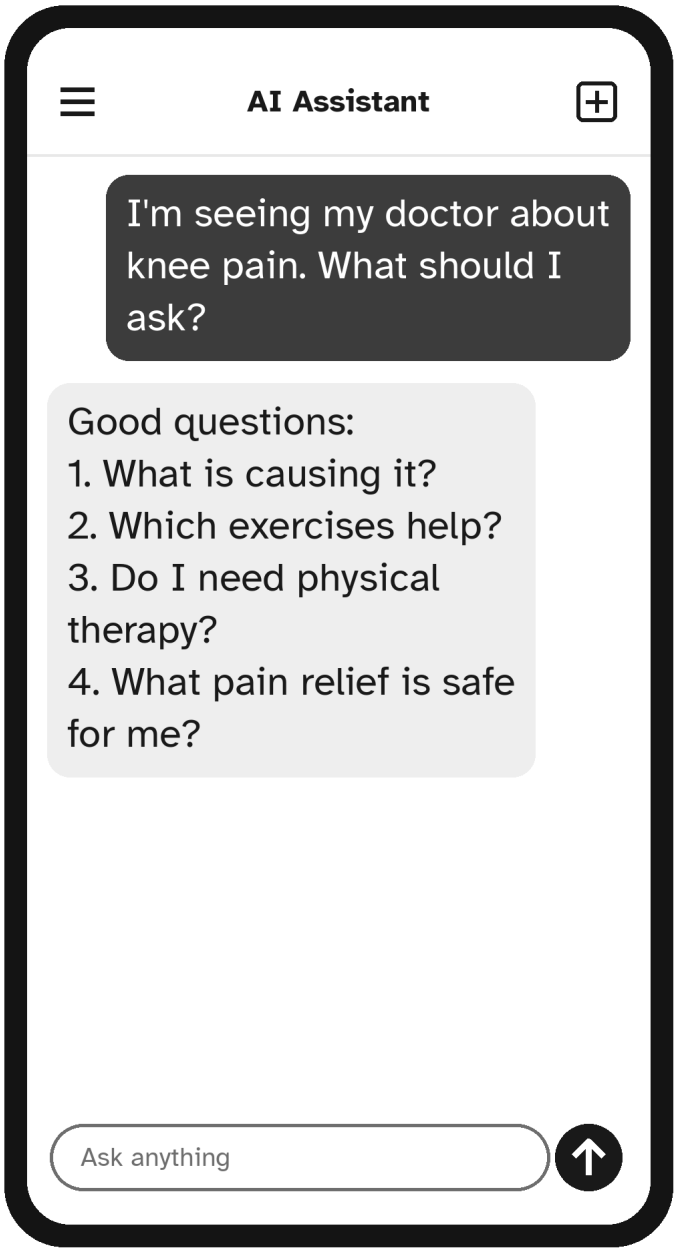
> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am seeing my doctor next week about knee pain that makes stairs difficult. I am 77. Please suggest eight questions I could ask, in order of importance, and a short list of things I should tell the doctor.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I have just been diagnosed with high blood pressure. What are the most important questions to ask my doctor at my next visit?

You can then print the list or write it in a notebook to take with you.

Learning About a Condition

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My doctor told me I have osteoarthritis in my hands. Please explain what that is in simple words, what usually helps, and what questions I should ask my doctor about treatment.



Preparing for an appointment: the AI suggests clear questions to take to the doctor.

When you read the answer, remember that it describes what is *usual*. Your own situation may be different, and that is exactly why the questions for your doctor matter.

Medicines: Ask the Pharmacist

AI can explain what a medicine is generally used for, or help you make a chart of when to take things. But questions about mixing medicines, side effects you are having, or changing doses belong with your pharmacist or doctor.

A good, safe use:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please make a simple daily chart with times for these medicines, as my doctor prescribed: one in the morning with breakfast, one at lunch, and two at bedtime.
> Leave space for me to tick each one.

Notice that you tell the AI the schedule from your prescription. You do not ask it to decide the schedule.

> **Safety Tip:** You do not need to give the AI your name, date of birth or other personal details to ask a health question. Ask it in general terms, such as "a woman in her 70s with high blood pressure," and keep your private details private.

Healthy Habits

This is an area where AI can be a cheerful, endlessly patient coach.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please suggest a gentle 10-minute exercise routine I can do sitting in a chair, for better balance and strength. I am 80. Describe each exercise in simple steps.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I'd like to eat more vegetables. Please suggest seven easy dinners for one person, each using no more than six ingredients.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I often wake up at 3 a.m. and can't get back to sleep. What are some simple habits that might help?

Before starting any new exercise routine, especially if you have a heart condition, joint problems or a history of falls, check with your doctor that it is right for you.

Worrying Answers

Sometimes reading about health makes us more anxious, not less. If an answer worries you:

1. Remember that the AI does not know your situation, and it may be wrong.
2. Do not search endlessly. Write down your worry.

3. Call your doctor's office or a nurse advice line and ask.

> **Try It:** Think of your next appointment, or one you had recently. Ask the AI to help you write five questions for it. Keep the list in your bag or wallet.

Key Points

- In an emergency, call 911 or your local emergency number first.
- Use AI to understand words and prepare questions, not to diagnose or decide.
- Tell the AI what your doctor prescribed; do not ask it to decide doses.
- Keep personal details private; ask in general terms.
- Check new exercise routines and anything worrying with a professional.

CHAPTER 8

Kitchen, Garden and Home

Some of the most satisfying uses of AI are the everyday ones: deciding what to cook, rescuing a struggling plant, or working out how to fix a dripping faucet. This chapter is full of practical examples to try.

What Can I Cook Tonight?

This is many people's favorite use. Tell the AI what you have, and it suggests what to make.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I have eggs, half a bag of spinach, some cheddar cheese, two potatoes and an onion. What can I make for one person for dinner? Something easy, please.

Follow-ups make it even better:

- "I don't have an oven, only a stove."

- "Make it softer; I have trouble chewing."
- "How long will it take?"
- "Can I freeze half for tomorrow?"

Recipes for Special Diets

YOU TYPE OR SAY

My doctor has asked me to eat less salt. Please suggest five tasty low-salt dinners, and some ways to add flavor without salt.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

My granddaughter is vegetarian and is visiting on Sunday. Please suggest a main dish that the whole family will enjoy, for six people.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please give me a classic apple pie recipe, but for a smaller pie for two people.

Note: If you have a serious allergy or a medical diet, double-check every ingredient on the actual packages. The AI can make mistakes about what foods contain.

Shopping Lists and Meal Plans

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please plan seven simple dinners for one person for the week, using cheap, healthy ingredients, with leftovers used the next day. Then make a shopping list grouped by supermarket section.

The shopping list can be copied into a note on your phone, or printed.

Measurements and Conversions

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> This recipe is in grams. Please convert 250 g flour, 100 g butter and 150 g sugar into cups and tablespoons.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> The recipe says 180°C. What is that in Fahrenheit?

In the Garden

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I live in North Carolina. What vegetables can I plant in raised beds in March? I'd like easy ones for a beginner.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> The leaves on my tomato plants are turning yellow from the bottom up. What might be causing this, and what should I try first?

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please suggest ten colorful flowers for a sunny patio in pots that are easy to look after and attract butterflies.

In Chapter 15, you will learn how to take a photo of a plant and ask the AI what it is, or what is wrong with it.

Around the House

AI can walk you through small jobs and help you decide when to call a professional.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My kitchen faucet drips all the time. Please explain the likely causes in simple words, and tell me which fixes are easy to do myself and when I should call a plumber.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

How do I reset my thermostat to a schedule: 68 degrees from 7 a.m. to 10 p.m., and 62 degrees at night? It is a programmable model with arrows and a "Program" button.

Safety Tip: For anything involving electricity, gas, ladders or heavy lifting, call a qualified professional or ask a family member. If you ever smell gas, leave the house and call your gas company's emergency number from outside.

Getting Your Gadgets to Work

AI assistants are very patient technology helpers.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I have an iPhone. How do I make the ringtone louder and turn on the flash light when I get a call? Please give step-by-step instructions in simple words.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

How do I send a photo from my Android phone to my daughter by email? Please explain each step.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My TV says "No Signal". What simple things can I check before calling someone?

If the steps do not match what you see on your screen, tell the AI exactly what you see: "*I don't have a button called Sound. I see Settings, Display and Battery.*" It will adjust its instructions.

Try It: Open your refrigerator or cupboard, list five ingredients, and ask the AI for a recipe. Bonus: actually cook it and tell a friend.

Key Points

- List what you have; the AI suggests what to cook.
- Ask for recipes that fit your diet, then check labels for allergies.
- Get planting and plant-care advice for your area.
- Use AI to understand small repairs, and call professionals for anything risky.
- Ask for step-by-step help with phones, TVs and gadgets, and say what you actually see.

CHAPTER 9

Learning New Hobbies and Skills



A grandmother happily practicing watercolor painting at a table, with a phone propped up beside her showing tips.

Retirement can be a wonderful time to learn: a language you always meant to study, the history behind a favorite place, an instrument, a craft. An AI assistant is like a patient private tutor who is available any hour of the day, never sighs, and never minds explaining something a fifth time.

Ask It to Teach You

The magic phrase is **"teach me."** Add what you already know, and how you like to learn.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please teach me the basics of birdwatching. I'm a complete beginner. Start with what equipment I need and five common birds I might see in my backyard in Pennsylvania.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Teach me how to play a simple card game I can play alone. Explain the rules step by step, slowly.

Learning a Language

AI is a superb language partner, because you can practice conversation without feeling shy.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I'd like to learn some Spanish before my trip to Mexico. Please teach me five useful phrases a day. Today, start with greetings, and test me afterward.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Let's practice ordering in a restaurant in French. You be the waiter. Speak simple French and correct my mistakes gently, in English.

Many AI apps can also speak out loud, so you can hear how words sound. (See Chapter 15.)

Exploring History and Science

Curious about something? Ask, and keep asking.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Tell me the story of how the Golden Gate Bridge was built, as if you were telling it to a friend over coffee.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Why is the sky blue? Please explain simply, then tell me one surprising fact about it.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

My father served in Korea in 1951. Please explain, in simple terms, what was happening there that year.

Arts, Crafts and Music

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I'd like to start watercolor painting. What do I need to buy to begin, for under $50? Then suggest three easy first projects.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please explain how to knit a simple scarf for a beginner, step by step, with the names of the stitches explained.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I am learning the piano. Please explain what a chord is, and how to play C major, F major and G major.

Reading and Book Clubs

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I loved "The Remains of the Day". Please recommend five similar novels, with a one-line description of each.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My book club is discussing "To Kill a Mockingbird". Please suggest eight thoughtful discussion questions.

Brain Games and Puzzles

Keeping the mind active is good for us, and AI can be a cheerful puzzle partner.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Let's play twenty questions. You think of an animal, and I will ask yes-or-no questions to guess it.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Give me a gentle quiz of ten questions about the 1960s, one question at a time. Tell me if I'm right after each.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please make me a crossword-style word puzzle with five clues about gardening. Give me the answers only when I ask.

Setting Learning Goals

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I want to learn to identify 30 trees in my local park by the end of spring. Please make me a simple twelve-week plan, with one small goal a week.

Try It: Choose one thing you have always wanted to learn. Ask the AI: "Please teach me the very first steps of [your hobby], as a complete beginner." Then ask it to test you on what you learned.

Key Points

- Say "teach me" and explain what you already know.
- Practice languages by role-playing conversations.
- Ask about history, science and nature, and keep asking follow-ups.
- Get beginner shopping lists and first projects for crafts and music.
- Play quizzes and word games to keep your mind active.

CHAPTER 10

Family, Grandchildren and Memories

Families are spread further apart than ever, and the world our grandchildren live in can feel very different from the one we grew up in. An AI assistant can help you stay connected: finding gifts, understanding what the grandchildren are talking about, playing games, and, perhaps most precious of all, recording your own life stories.

Gift Ideas

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please suggest ten gift ideas for my granddaughter, who is 9, loves horses and drawing, and already has lots of toys. Budget: $25 to $40.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

What is a thoughtful gift for my son and his wife, who have just bought their first house? Something personal, not just a gift card.

Understanding the Grandchildren

Not sure what a word, game or app is? Ask.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

My 14-year-old grandson keeps talking about "Minecraft" and "Roblox". What are they, in simple words, and are they safe for his age?

YOU TYPE OR SAY

What does "no cap" mean? My granddaughter said it and I didn't want to ask.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

What questions could I ask my teenage grandson to start a conversation, other than "How's school?"

Games and Activities to Share

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My grandchildren, aged 6 and 9, are staying with me this weekend. It may rain. Please suggest ten indoor activities using things I probably have at home.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please write a short bedtime story about a brave little hedgehog called Pip, for a 5-year-old. About five minutes to read aloud.

You can even ask the AI to put your grandchild into the story, using only their first name. Children love it.

Recording Your Life Stories

Your memories are a treasure for your family. Many people mean to write them down but never know where to start. An AI assistant can interview you, one question at a time, and then help you shape your answers into stories.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

I would like to write my life story for my grandchildren. Please interview me, one question at a time, starting with my childhood. Wait for my answer before asking the next question.

Answer each question in your own words. Do not worry about spelling or neatness. After a few questions, ask:

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please turn my answers so far into a short, warm story, written in my own voice, keeping my own words where possible.

You can do this a little at a time, one chat per period of your life: childhood, school, work, marriage, children, adventures. Copy each story into a document or email it to yourself, and one day you will have a book of memories for your family.

Note: Treat your stories like a private diary. Keep private matters, like addresses, health details and financial information, out of them, or check with family before sharing.



The AI as a gentle interviewer: one question at a time, for a family memory book.

Family History

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My grandparents came from Ireland to Boston in the 1920s. Please explain where I could start looking for records of their journey, and what information I should gather from my family first.

The AI can suggest where to look, such as archives, census records and libraries, but it cannot look up your actual family records. Always check names and dates in real documents.

Staying in Touch

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please help me write a short, cheerful weekly email to my family, telling them about my week: I visited the library, my tomatoes are ripening, and I saw an old friend at church.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> How can I make a video call to my daughter from my iPad? Please give simple step-by-step instructions.

Try It: Start the interview: copy the life-story request above and answer the first three questions. You might be surprised how quickly memories come back.

Key Points

- Get gift ideas by describing the person, their interests and your budget.
- Ask what new words, games and apps mean.
- Make up stories and games to share with grandchildren.
- Let the AI interview you to record your life stories.
- Use it for ideas on family history, then check real records.

CHAPTER 11

Money, Bills and Paperwork

Official letters, bills and forms can be confusing even for experts. An AI assistant can help you understand them, organize your budget, and write clear replies. This chapter shows you how, and how to do it without sharing anything private.

> **Warning:** An AI assistant is not a financial adviser, accountant or lawyer. Use it to understand and organize. For important decisions about savings, investments, taxes, wills or legal matters, speak to a qualified professional.

The Golden Privacy Rule for Paperwork

Before you paste anything from a letter or bill into an AI, **remove the private details**:

- Your full name and address
- Account numbers, policy numbers and customer numbers
- Your Social Security number or any ID number

- Your date of birth
- Card numbers, PINs and passwords

You can simply type the part you want explained, or replace the details with words like *[my account]*.

Understanding a Confusing Letter

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I received a letter from my health insurance that says:
> "Your claim has been processed. The provider's charges exceeded the allowed amount, and the difference is your responsibility as an out-of-network service."
> What does this mean, in plain English? What should I do next?

The AI will explain each part, and will often suggest sensible next steps, such as calling the insurer to ask about an appeal. Then you call the number printed on your letter.

Understanding a Bill

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My electricity bill has a line called "delivery charge" and another called "supply charge". What is the difference? Why do I pay both?

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My phone bill went up by $15 this month. What are common reasons for a sudden increase, and what should I ask the phone company?

A Simple Budget

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please help me make a simple monthly budget. My income is about $2,800 a month from my pension and Social Security. My regular costs are: rent $1,100, utilities $180, phone and internet $90, food $400, medicines $60, car $250. Please show it as a table and tell me what is left over.

You do not need to give real account details. Rounded amounts are enough.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please suggest ten simple ways a retired person living alone can save money on everyday bills.

Words You Don't Understand

YOU TYPE OR SAY

What is the difference between a Roth IRA and a traditional IRA? Please explain in simple words, with an example.

YOU TYPE OR SAY

What is a "required minimum distribution"? Does it apply to me if I'm 75? I'll confirm with my accountant.

Writing a Clear Reply

YOU TYPE OR SAY

Please write a short, polite letter to my bank asking them to explain a $35 fee on my statement dated March 3, and asking for it to be refunded because I have never been charged it before. Leave blanks for my name and account number.

Forms

Forms can be long and full of official words. You can ask what a section means:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I am filling in a form, and one question asks for my "adjusted gross income". What is that, and where would I find it?

> **Safety Tip:** Never type your real Social Security number, bank details or passwords into an AI chat, even to "check a form." Fill in those parts yourself, directly on the official form or website.

Is This a Scam?

Many scams arrive looking like bills, refunds or official letters. If something seems off, AI can help you think it through. Copy the words of the message (without your personal details) and ask:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I received this text message. Does it look like a scam? What are the warning signs, and what should I do?
>
> "USPS: Your package is on hold due to an unpaid shipping fee of $1.99. Pay now to avoid return: [link]"

The next chapter covers scams in detail.

> **Try It:** Find a non-private letter or leaflet you didn't fully understand: a warranty, a leaflet from your utility company, or the terms on a store card. Type one confusing sentence into the AI and ask it to explain.

Key Points

- Remove names, numbers and private details before asking.
- Ask the AI to explain confusing letters and bills in plain English.
- Make a simple budget using rounded amounts.
- Get help writing clear, polite letters with blanks for your details.
- For big decisions, speak to a qualified professional.

PART III

Staying Safe

CHAPTER 12

Spotting Scams, Old and New



An older woman on the phone at home, looking thoughtful and cautious, with a notepad beside her.

Scammers target everyone, but they often target older adults, because many of us have savings, a home, and a polite habit of answering the phone. Today, scammers also use AI to make their tricks more convincing. The good news: the same few warning signs give away almost every scam, and an AI assistant can help you check suspicious messages.

The Five Warning Signs

Almost every scam has at least one of these:

1. **Pressure and hurry.** "Act now!" "Today only!" "Your account will be closed in one hour!"
2. **Secrecy.** "Don't tell your family." "Don't tell the bank why you're withdrawing the money."
3. **Strange ways to pay.** Gift cards, wire transfers, cryptocurrency, payment apps, or cash handed to a courier.
4. **Unexpected contact.** A call, text or email you were not expecting, about a prize, a problem, or a relative in trouble.
5. **Requests for private information.** Passwords, codes sent to your phone, bank details or ID numbers.

> **Remember:** No real bank, government agency or company will ever ask you to pay with gift cards, or to read out a code they just sent to your phone. Anyone who does is a scammer.

New: Scams That Use AI

AI tools can copy a person's voice from a short recording, such as a video posted online. Scammers use this for the **"family emergency" scam**: you get a call from what sounds exactly like your grandchild, crying, saying they have been in an accident or arrested and need money urgently, and begging you not to tell their parents.

It can sound completely real. Here is how to protect yourself:

- **Agree on a family code word.** Choose a word together, in person, that only your family knows. Something unusual, like "pineapple tractor". If someone calls asking for money in an emergency, ask for the code word. No word, no money.
- **Hang up and call back** on the number you already have for that person, or call their parents.
- **Slow down.** Real emergencies can wait the five minutes it takes to check.

Scammers also use AI to write convincing emails and texts without spelling mistakes, and to make fake videos of famous people "recommending" investments. If a celebrity seems to be promoting a get-rich-quick scheme, it is almost certainly fake.

> **Safety Tip:** Set up your family code word this week. Call or visit your children and grandchildren, explain why, and choose the word together. Write it somewhere private at home, not on your phone.

Common Scams to Know

The "your computer has a virus" scam. A pop-up or phone call says your computer is infected and you must call a number or let someone connect to your computer. Never do either. Close the browser, or switch the computer off and on again.

The delivery scam. A text says a package can't be delivered unless you pay a small fee through a link. Delete it. Check deliveries on the shop's official website or app instead.

The bank fraud scam. Someone claiming to be from your bank's "fraud department" calls and asks you to move money to a "safe account," or to read out a code. Hang up and call the number on the back of your card.

The government scam. A caller says you owe taxes or that your Social Security number has been "suspended," and threatens arrest. Real government agencies send letters and do not threaten you on the phone.

The romance scam. A friendly stranger online becomes a close companion over weeks or months, then needs money for an emergency, a ticket, or a medical bill. Never send money to someone you have not met in person.

The prize scam. You have "won" a lottery or sweepstakes you never entered, but must pay a fee to collect. Real prizes do not cost money to claim.

Using AI to Check a Suspicious Message

Your AI assistant can be a helpful second opinion. Copy the message, **remove your personal details**, and ask:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I received this message. Is it likely a scam? Please list the warning signs and tell me what to do.
>
> [paste the message here]

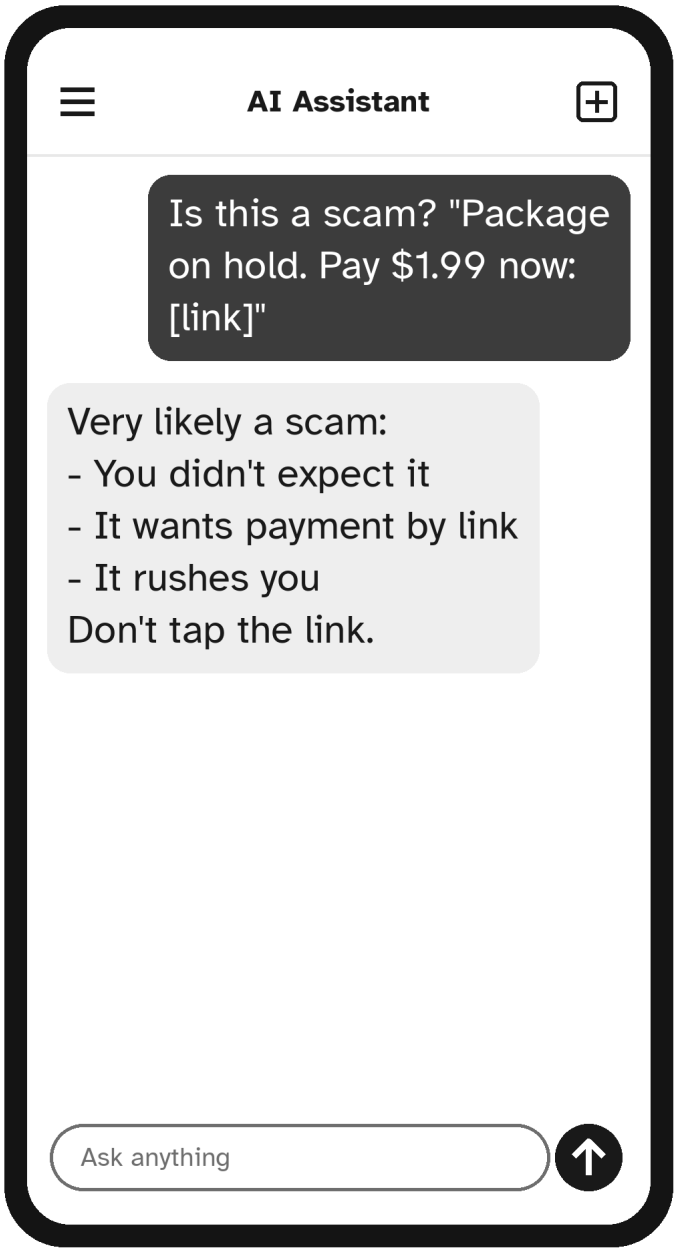
The AI will point out the warning signs and suggest safe next steps. If it says the message looks genuine, still **check by contacting the company yourself**, using a phone number or website you already know, not the one in the message.

> **Warning:** Never click links or call numbers in a suspicious message, even to check. Find the real phone number on your card, your statement, or the company's official website.

If You Think You Have Been Scammed

Don't be embarrassed. Scammers are professionals, and they fool clever, careful people every day. Act quickly:

1. **Call your bank** using the number on the back of your card. Tell them what happened. They may be able to stop a payment.



A second opinion on a suspicious text: the AI points out the warning signs.

2. **Change any passwords** you may have shared, or ask a family member to help.
3. **Report it.** In the United States, report scams to the Federal Trade Commission at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**. If you are 60 or older, you can also call the **National Elder Fraud Hotline** at **833-FRAUD-11** (833-372-8311); check the current opening hours

at **justice.gov/stopelderfraud**. In other countries, contact your national fraud reporting service or the police.

4. **Tell someone you trust.** Talking about it helps, and warns others.

> **Try It:** Ask your AI assistant: "What are the most common scams targeting older adults right now, and how can I spot each one?" Then share one tip with a friend.

Key Points

- Pressure, secrecy, odd payment methods, unexpected contact and requests for private details are the five warning signs.
- AI can fake a loved one's voice: agree on a family code word.
- Hang up and call back on a number you already know.
- Ask your AI assistant for a second opinion, but check with the company directly.
- If something happens, call your bank quickly and report it.

CHAPTER 13

Privacy: What Not to Tell an AI

AI assistants are run by companies, and what you type is sent to their computers to produce an answer. Well-known companies take security seriously, but it is wise to treat an AI chat a little like a postcard: fine for most things, not for secrets.

Never Type These

Keep these out of every AI chat, always:

- **Passwords and PINs**, for anything
- **Codes sent to your phone** by text message
- **Bank account and card numbers**
- **Social Security, Medicare, passport or driver's license numbers**
- **Your full date of birth together with your full name and address**

- **Other people's private details**, such as a friend's medical problems or address

Fine to Share, in General Terms

You can get excellent help without personal details. Instead of names and numbers, describe the situation:

Instead of this	Try this
"I'm Mary Jones, born 3/14/1950, at 12 Oak St."	"I'm a woman in my 70s."
"My account number 4417… has a fee"	"My bank charged me a $35 fee."
"My neighbor Bob has dementia"	"A neighbor of mine has memory problems."
A photo of your whole prescription label	Type just the medicine name

Your Chat History

Most assistants keep a history of your conversations, so you can return to them. In the app's **settings** you can usually:

- **Delete** a single conversation, or all of them
- Turn off whether your chats are **used to improve** the company's AI (often called "training" or "improve the model")
- Use a **temporary** or **private** chat that is not saved

To find these, look for **Settings** (often under your name or picture, or a gear icon), then a section called **Data**, **Privacy** or **Data controls**. The exact words vary between apps. If you can't find them, ask the assistant itself:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> How do I delete my chat history and turn off using my chats for training in this app?

Note: Ask the AI app about its own settings, then follow its steps. If the steps don't match your screen, tell it what you see.

Keep Your Account Safe

- **Use a strong, unique password** for your AI account, different from your email and bank passwords.
- **Turn on two-step sign-in** if the app offers it. This means you get a code by text or email when signing in on a new device.
- **Never share** your sign-in codes with anyone who calls or messages you.
- **Sign out** if you use a shared or public computer, such as at the library.

Shared Devices

If you share a tablet or computer with family members, remember they may be able to see your chat history. That's fine for recipes and trip plans; for anything personal, use a private chat or delete it afterward.

Children and AI

If grandchildren use your phone or tablet, sit with them when they use an AI assistant. Most AI services have minimum ages in their rules, often 13 or 18, and younger children should only use AI with an adult.

> **Try It:** Open your AI app's settings and find the privacy or data section. You don't have to change anything; just know where it is. If you can't find it, ask the AI how.

Key Points

- Never type passwords, codes, account numbers or ID numbers.
- Describe situations in general terms; it works just as well.
- Find the privacy settings: delete chats and turn off training if you prefer.
- Protect your account with a unique password and two-step sign-in.
- On shared devices, use private chats or delete personal ones.

CHAPTER 14

When the AI Gets It Wrong

Even the best AI assistants make mistakes. Sometimes they make up a fact, a date, a book title or a website, and say it as confidently as everything else. Experts call this **hallucinating**. Knowing this, and knowing how to catch it, is one of the most important skills in this book.

Why It Happens

An AI assistant does not look facts up in a reliable encyclopedia every time. It writes the answer that *sounds* most likely, based on everything it learned. Most of the time that answer is right. Sometimes it is a confident guess, and the guess is wrong.

It is like a well-read friend who never likes to say "I don't know."

Where Mistakes Are Most Likely

Be especially careful with:

- **Numbers**: prices, dates, doses, phone numbers, statistics
- **Specific facts**: names, addresses, opening hours, laws and rules
- **Very recent events**: news, new products, changed prices
- **Quotations and references**: book titles, articles, websites
- **Local details**: your town's bus times, your county's rules
- **Math with many steps**

It is usually very reliable for: explaining ideas, writing and rewriting, brainstorming, and general knowledge that has been true for a long time.

Five Ways to Catch a Mistake

1. Ask how sure it is.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> How confident are you about that? Which parts might be wrong or out of date?

2. Ask where the information comes from. Some assistants can search the web and show **sources**: small links under the answer. Tap them to see the original page. If an assistant cannot show sources, ask it where you could check.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Where could I check this on an official website?

3. Ask the question a different way. If you get two different answers, at least one of them is wrong. Check with a trusted source.

4. Use common sense. If an answer seems surprising, too good to be true, or worrying, pause and check.

5. Check with the real source. For anything important:

Topic	Check with
Health and medicines	Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist
Money and taxes	Your bank, an accountant, or the official tax agency
Legal matters	A lawyer or legal aid service
Travel	The airline, hotel or official tourism website
Opening hours and prices	The business's own website, or a phone call
Benefits and pensions	The official government agency

Telling It About a Mistake

If you know an answer is wrong, simply say so:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> That's not right. The library closes at 5 p.m., not 8 p.m. Please update the plan.

The assistant will apologize and correct itself within the conversation. (It won't remember the correction in a new chat.)

A Healthy Attitude

Think of the AI as a helpful assistant who is brilliant at writing and explaining, but who you would never let sign a check on your behalf. It drafts, suggests and explains. **You** decide, and **you** check the things that matter.

> **Try It:** Ask your AI assistant about something you know very well, such as your hometown, your old job or a hobby. See if you can spot anything it gets wrong. It's a good way to get a feel for how much to trust it.

Key Points

- AI can make up facts and sound completely sure.
- Be careful with numbers, specific facts, recent events and references.
- Ask how sure it is and where to check.
- Confirm important things with the real source.
- You decide; the AI only suggests.

PART IV

Going Further

CHAPTER 15

Talking Instead of Typing, and Using Your Camera



A grandfather in an armchair talking to his phone, which is listening and answering out loud.

Typing on a small screen can be slow, especially if your fingers are stiff or your eyesight is tired. The good news is that you can **talk** to most AI assistants, and many can **talk back**. Some can even **see** through your phone's camera.

Speaking Your Message

The simplest way to talk is to use the microphone on your keyboard.

1. Tap the message box, so the keyboard appears.
2. Look for a small **microphone** icon on the keyboard (often near the space bar) or next to the message box.
3. Tap it and speak normally. Your words appear as text.
4. Check the words, fix any mistakes, and tap **send**.

Speak clearly at a normal pace. You can say punctuation, too: say "comma", "period" or "question mark" where you want them.

> **Tip:** The first time you use the microphone, your phone will ask for permission to use it. Tap **Allow**. This is normal for well-known apps.

A Real Spoken Conversation

Many AI apps have a **voice mode**, where you talk and the AI answers out loud, like a phone call. Look for a button with a sound-wave symbol, a headphones symbol, or the word **Voice**, usually near the message box.

In voice mode:

- Just talk. When you pause, the AI answers out loud.
- You can interrupt it by speaking, if you want to change direction.
- Tap the **X** or **End** button to finish.

Voice mode is lovely for practicing a language, getting cooking instructions while your hands are busy, or simply chatting about a topic you're curious about.

> **Note:** Not every app or device has voice mode, and some features need the latest version of the app. If you can't find it, ask the AI: "Do you have a voice mode in this app, and how do I start it?"

Listening to Answers

If you prefer to read your messages but hear the answers, many apps have a **read aloud** button (often a small speaker icon) under each answer. Tap it to hear the answer spoken.

Your phone also has built-in features that can read the screen aloud. Ask your AI assistant:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> How do I make my iPhone read the text on the screen out loud? Please give simple steps.

Using Your Camera

Many AI assistants can look at a photo and tell you about it. This opens up wonderful possibilities:

- **Reading small print**: a medicine leaflet, a menu in a dim restaurant, a label in a store
- **Identifying things**: a plant, a bird, a mushroom in the garden (but never eat anything based on an AI's guess)
- **Understanding things**: "What is this warning light on my car's dashboard?"
- **Helping with gadgets**: a photo of the back of your TV, asking which cable goes where

To share a photo, look for a **paperclip**, **plus (+)** or **camera** button next to the message box. You can take a new photo or choose one from your gallery. Then add a question:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> What kind of plant is this, and how do I look after it?

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> Please read the instructions on this leaflet and tell me the main points in simple words, in large text.



Asking about a photo: the AI identifies a garden plant and gives care tips.

Safety Tip: Before sharing a photo, check what is in it. Do not share photos of documents showing account numbers, ID cards, prescriptions with your full details, or other people who haven't agreed to it.

Making a Phone Easier to Use

Ask your AI assistant to help you with your phone's accessibility features, the settings designed to make phones easier for everyone:

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> I have an Android phone and I find the screen hard to read. What settings can make it easier? Please list them with simple steps.

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
> My hands shake a little, and I often tap the wrong thing on my iPhone. Are there settings that can help?

Try It: Ask your AI assistant a question by speaking instead of typing. Then try sharing a photo of something in your home, such as a houseplant or a piece of fruit, and ask it what it sees.

Key Points

- Use the keyboard microphone to speak instead of typing.
- Try voice mode for real spoken conversations.
- Use the read aloud button to hear answers.
- Share photos to read small print, identify plants, or understand gadgets.
- Check photos for private information before sharing.

CHAPTER 16

Your One-Week Practice Plan

The best way to become comfortable with an AI assistant is to use it a little every day. Here is a gentle plan for your first week. Each day takes about ten to fifteen minutes. Write the date on the line when you have done each day.

Day 1: Say Hello

- Open your AI assistant.
- Ask: "*What are three things you can help me with today?*"
- Ask one follow-up question.

Done on: _____

Day 2: Write Something

- Ask the AI to help you write a short message to a friend or family member.
- Ask it to change one thing: warmer, shorter, or funnier.
- Copy it and send it.

Done on: _____

Day 3: Plan Something

- Ask for a dinner idea using what is in your kitchen, or plan a short outing.
- Use the "golden rules" from Chapter 4: say who it is for, and how you want the answer.

Done on: _____

Day 4: Learn Something

- Ask the AI to teach you about something you have always been curious about.
- Ask it to quiz you with three questions afterward.

Done on: _____

Day 5: Stay Safe

- Ask: "*What are the most common scams targeting older adults right now?*"
- Agree on a family code word with your relatives (Chapter 12).
- Find the privacy settings in your AI app (Chapter 13).

Done on: _____

Day 6: Talk and Look

- Ask a question by speaking instead of typing.
- Share a photo of a plant, an object or a label, and ask about it.

Done on: _____

Day 7: Your Choice

- Pick any page of the **100 Ready-to-Use Questions** at the back of this book and try three of them.
- Tell someone what you learned this week.

Done on: _____

After the First Week

Here are some ideas for keeping up the habit:

- **Morning question.** Each morning, ask one question you have wondered about: a word, a fact, a recipe.
- **Weekly letter.** Use AI to help write a weekly email to family.
- **Monthly project.** Choose one bigger project: a family memory book, a garden plan, or learning fifty words of a language.
- **Teach someone else.** Show a friend how you use it. Teaching is the best way to learn.

When You Get Stuck

You will sometimes get stuck. Everyone does, including people who use AI every day. When it happens:

1. Start a new chat and ask again, more simply.
2. Tell the AI exactly what you see on your screen.
3. Ask it: "*I'm confused. Can you explain that step again, more slowly?*"
4. Ask a family member or friend to sit with you for ten minutes.
5. Many public libraries and senior centers run free technology help sessions. Ask yours.

A Final Word

You have learned something many people half your age are still nervous about. You know what an AI assistant is, how to ask it for help, how to use it for writing, planning, learning and family, and, most importantly, how to use it safely.

The rest is simply practice and curiosity. Ask it about the things you love. Ask it the questions you were always too shy to ask anyone. And remember: you are the one in charge. The AI is just a very clever helper.

Enjoy it.

Appendix A: 100 Ready-to-Use Questions

Copy any of these into your AI assistant, word for word, or change the words in brackets to fit your life. They are grouped by topic, so you can find what you need quickly.

Getting to Know Your AI

1. What are ten useful things you can help a retired person with?
2. Please explain how you work, in three simple sentences.
3. What should I never share with you, and why?
4. How do I start a new chat in this app?
5. How can I make the text bigger in this app?
6. Can you speak your answers out loud? How do I turn that on?
7. What is the best way to ask you a question to get a good answer?
8. How sure are you about your last answer?
9. Please explain that again, more simply, in large words.

10. Please summarize our conversation in five bullet points.

Writing and Messages

11. Write a thank-you note to [name] for [what they did], about four sentences.
12. Write a cheerful birthday message for my [grandson], who is turning [age] and loves [hobby].
13. Write a Christmas card message for an old friend I haven't seen in years.
14. Help me write a polite complaint to [company] about [problem]. Leave blanks for my details.
15. Check the spelling and grammar of my message below, keeping my own words.
16. Make this email warmer and less formal.
17. Help me write a short speech for [occasion], about two minutes long.
18. Help me reply kindly to an invitation I need to decline.
19. Write a short note for the church or club newsletter about [event].
20. Suggest five ways to start a letter to a grandchild.

Trips and Outings

21. Suggest five relaxing day trips within an hour of [your town], with little walking.

22. Plan a [5]-day trip to [place] for two people in their [70s], with rests every afternoon.
23. Make a packing list for a [7]-day trip to [place] in [month].
24. What questions should I ask a hotel about accessibility before booking?
25. Teach me ten useful phrases in [language] for my trip, with pronunciation.
26. Tell me five interesting stories from the history of [place] to look out for.
27. What should I check before taking a long car journey?
28. How do I keep my medicines safe and on schedule while traveling? Give me questions for my pharmacist.
29. What are common travel scams, and how can I avoid them?
30. Plan a lovely afternoon in [town] for my grandchildren aged [ages].

Health and Wellbeing

31. Explain these words from my test results in plain English: [words].
32. Suggest eight questions to ask my doctor about [condition].
33. Explain [condition] in simple words, and what usually helps.
34. Suggest a gentle 10-minute chair exercise routine for balance.
35. Make a daily chart for my medicines, as prescribed: [schedule].
36. What are simple habits that help with better sleep?

37. Suggest ways to stay socially connected when living alone.
38. What should I keep in an emergency information folder at home?
39. Explain what a [specialist name] does, and what to expect at a first visit.
40. Suggest five simple ways to drink more water during the day.

Cooking and Food

41. I have [ingredients]. What can I make for one person tonight?
42. Suggest five tasty low-salt dinners.
43. Halve this recipe for two people: [recipe].
44. Plan seven simple dinners for the week and a shopping list.
45. Convert [amount] in grams to cups.
46. Suggest soft foods that are easy to chew and still nutritious.
47. Give me a classic [dish] recipe, like my mother used to make.
48. What can I bake with my grandchildren that's easy and fun?
49. How long can I safely keep [food] in the refrigerator?
50. Suggest a menu for a small holiday dinner for [number] people.

Garden and Home

51. What can I plant in [month] in [state or region]?
52. My [plant]'s leaves are [problem]. What might be wrong?

53. Suggest easy flowers for pots on a [sunny or shady] patio.
54. How do I attract more birds to my garden?
55. My [appliance] is [problem]. What can I safely check myself?
56. When should I call a professional for [household problem]?
57. Give me a simple spring cleaning plan, one small task a day.
58. How can I make my home safer against falls?
59. How do I [task] on my [phone or tablet model]? Step by step, please.
60. My TV shows [message]. What simple things can I check?

Learning and Hobbies

61. Teach me the basics of [hobby] as a complete beginner.
62. Recommend five books similar to [book I loved].
63. Suggest eight discussion questions for my book club about [book].
64. Tell me the story of [historical event] as if over coffee.
65. Quiz me with ten questions about [topic], one at a time.
66. Let's play twenty questions. You think of an animal.
67. Explain [science question] simply, with one surprising fact.
68. Make a twelve-week plan for learning [skill], one small goal a week.

69. Practice a simple conversation with me in [language], and correct me gently.
70. Suggest five free or low-cost activities for retirees in [town].

Family and Memories

71. Suggest ten gift ideas for my [relative], age [age], who loves [interests]. Budget [amount].
72. What does [word or slang] mean? My grandchild said it.
73. What are [game or app], and are they safe for a [age]-year-old?
74. Suggest ten indoor activities for grandchildren aged [ages] on a rainy day.
75. Write a short bedtime story about [animal] called [name], for a [age]-year-old.
76. Interview me about my childhood, one question at a time, for a memory book.
77. Turn my answers into a short story in my own voice.
78. Where could I start researching my family history from [country]?
79. Suggest questions to ask my older relatives about our family history.
80. Help me write a cheerful weekly update email to my family.

Money and Paperwork

81. Explain this sentence from a letter in plain English: [sentence].

82. What is the difference between [term] and [term]?

83. Help me make a simple monthly budget from these rounded amounts: [amounts].

84. Suggest ten ways to save money on everyday bills.

85. Write a polite letter asking my bank to explain a fee. Leave blanks for my details.

86. What does [form question] mean, and where would I find that information?

87. What questions should I ask before signing a contract for [service]?

88. How do I know if a charity is genuine before I donate?

89. Explain what a will and a power of attorney are, in simple words. I'll see a lawyer for advice.

90. What should I keep and what can I shred among old paperwork? I'll confirm with my accountant.

Staying Safe

91. Is this message a scam? What are the warning signs? [message without personal details]

92. What are the most common scams targeting older adults right now?

93. How can my family and I use a code word to stop voice-cloning scams?

94. What should I do if I think I've been scammed?

95. How do I recognize a fake website?

96. How do I delete my chat history in this app?

97. How do I turn on two-step sign-in for my email account?

98. How can I make a strong password that I can remember?

99. What should I do if a pop-up says my computer has a virus?

100. How do I block a phone number that keeps calling me?

Appendix B: Plain-English Word List

AI (artificial intelligence). Computer programs that can do things we usually think need human intelligence, such as understanding language or recognizing pictures.

AI assistant (or chatbot). An app or website where you can have a written or spoken conversation with an AI.

App. A program on a phone or tablet. You get apps from your device's official app store: the App Store on iPhones and iPads, and Google Play (the Play Store) on Android devices.

Browser. The program you use to visit websites on a computer, phone or tablet.

Chat (or conversation). One back-and-forth exchange with an AI assistant on one topic. You can start a new chat at any time. Most assistants keep a list of your past chats, called your **chat history**, so you can return to them.

Cloud. Computers owned by a company, reached over the internet, where your information can be stored or processed.

Copy and paste. Copying text from one place and putting it in another. On a phone, press and hold, then choose Copy or Paste.

Free version (or free plan). The version of an AI assistant you can use without paying. It is enough for everything in this book.

Hallucination. When an AI states something false as if it were true.

Link. Words or a button you tap or click to go to a web page. Never tap links in suspicious messages.

Prompt. The message or question you send to an AI assistant. In this book, prompts are shown in shaded boxes.

Scam. A trick to steal money or information. Warning signs: pressure, secrecy, strange payment methods and unexpected contact.

Settings. The part of an app or device where you change how it works, such as text size or privacy.

Source. Where information comes from. Some AI assistants show links to their sources under an answer.

Two-step sign-in (two-factor authentication). Extra protection: after your password, you enter a code sent to your phone or email.

Voice cloning. Using AI to copy someone's voice from a recording. Scammers use it to pretend to be family members.

Voice mode. A way of talking to an AI assistant out loud, with the assistant answering out loud.

Appendix C: Quick Reference

Keep this sheet beside your phone or computer.

Asking Well: The Recipe

> **YOU TYPE OR SAY**
>
> I am [who you are or your situation].
> Please help me [what you want].
> It is for [who or what it is for].
> Please [how you want the answer].

Handy Follow-Ups

- "Shorter, please."
- "Explain that more simply."
- "Make it warmer and more personal."
- "How sure are you? What should I check?"

The Buttons

Button	What it does
Arrow	Sends your message
Pencil or plus	Starts a new chat
Three short lines	Opens the menu and your old chats

Button	What it does
Two squares	Copies the answer
Microphone	Speaks instead of typing
Paperclip, plus or camera	Adds a photo

The Safety Rules

1. **Never** type passwords, PINs, codes or ID numbers.
2. **Check** anything important with a trusted source.
3. **In an emergency**, call 911 or your local emergency number first.
4. **Pressure, secrecy and gift cards** mean scam. Hang up and call back on a number you know.
5. **Agree on a family code word** for phone emergencies.

My Notes

My AI assistant is called: _____

Helpful person to call if I get stuck: _____

Three things I want help with:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

(Do not write passwords on this page.)

About the Author

Aadhavan Muthurengan writes clear, practical guides to artificial intelligence and technology for everyday readers. His books explain how to use AI tools with confidence, step by step, with an emphasis on safety and real-life examples.

He wrote this book for parents and grandparents who want to enjoy the benefits of AI without the jargon, and for the families who love them.

If this book helped you, a short review on Amazon helps other readers find it. Thank you.